

Looking Closer at Data: In Search of Good Governance

Good data management saves cost and time for civil servants in performing their official chores

The GIZ *Entwicklungsdienst* has been working in the city of Kupang since April 2010 and will continue its cooperation until April 2012. Together with the official counterpart, the Local Development and Planning Agency Bappeda, the cooperation's agreed focus is on Data Management.

Data management has a priority in the planning and decision-making process in Bappeda and Kota Kupang. In general it can be said that with good data management, Bappeda Kota Kupang will be in a better position to execute more successful “City Planning” and “Economic Development”. Since the strategic plan has focused on creating digital maps, a good and effective collection of data represents a clear priority. Beyond the technical aspects on the benefits of good data management, one can appreciate that a competent and informed management of data is imperative for any government or authority to meet its responsibility to secure a transparent and reliable decision-making process for its citizens.

A questionnaire for the Systematization of Data and Duties

In order to create an effective database, GIZ *Entwicklungsdienst* start with a questionnaire to understand some very basic and yet essential questions: firstly, what is the data needed for (purpose); secondly, what kind of data is needed, and when; thirdly, how will data be collected and saved (the practical execution of the process); and last but not least, how will the data be accessed



and shared.

The answers to all these questions were gathered through questionnaires. The questionnaire was designed for interviewing Bappeda employees about how they usually save data, how it is stored and what the main products are. Basically, the parties involved needed to make sense of an unmanageable flow of information that had not been put into a systemized order yet.

The data surveyed included a wide range of information from monthly reports and maps to other documents such as advice on specific decision-

making processes, analytical reports/studies, monitoring-evaluation reports, data and information about development planning, and so forth.

Analyzing Data and Workflow

Once the nature and context of the data was understood, the next step was to understand for whom do Bappeda employees make these products and what the specific purpose of each product is that they have been producing throughout the year. All this has been done to improve the workflow and data management between the departments in Bappeda Kota Kupang

and for Bappeda itself.

The questionnaire started with three lists that enumerate the products Bappeda staff have to make, with whom the employees work and the different roles they have while making different products. Next the questionnaire addressed how data is saved or the way the products are put into use and where they originated. The questionnaire concluded with personnel-related enquires such as the name and position of individuals and their wish on what they would like to see improved in the future.

Through a data- and workflow analysis, the stakeholders found out that there were three main working areas for the information products of Bappeda: 1. On political and democratic processes, 2. On planning, and 3. On facts collection and evaluation. Accordingly, all data has been organized into these

three categories. It is a very significant step forward on the way to achieve more structured data management.

A breakthrough: Understanding Products and their Purposes

Another import lesson the stakeholders have learnt is that only by knowing the main products, in other words attaching a concrete and precisely defined purpose to it with a clear time-schedule, will Bappeda be able to articulate clear goals. To communicate this to the partner was one of GIZ *Entwicklungsdienst* staff's biggest breakthroughs, because evidently without clear defined goals, it is quite impossible to meet any decisive objective whatsoever. A well-structured and channeled common working process, on the other hand, will guarantee to deliver results and thereby lift up everybody's motivations.

Conclusion

GIZ *Entwicklungsdienst* is still optimistic that the impacts will have an effect, because Bappeda employees now cannot only save time to work on specific products (data is safe and can be shared easily-better access), but good data management also reduces the cost and time of having to maintain several databases in one administration. In addition, it reduces time and cost of producing specific products (official reports, planning documents, etc.). In the long run, improved data management is essential to achieve greater transparency and accountability which leads to good governance in the city of Kupang.

Jürgen Mark Lembcke and Fransiska Faletina Sugi.



Abstract of Bappeda Kota Kupang: Bappeda (Badan Perencanaan Pembangunan Daerah, Local

Development Planning Agency) of the city of Kupang is one of the Local Government Agencies that is generally responsible for the development planning in the city of Kupang. Basically, there are three main products of Bappeda: the political and democratic process, planning, and facts collection & evaluation.

Jürgen Mark Lembcke is a Senior Advisor and helps Bappeda in creating good Data Management based on workflow and data flow in Bappeda, as a base for better planning. His professional background before joining GIZ *Entwicklungsdienst* was as head of the German Institute for Town Center Development (*Deutsches Seminar für Städtebau und Wirtschaft DSSW*), Berlin since 1999, previous work at the Institute for Urban Research and Structural Policy (*IfS GmbH*), and studies at the Institute of Urban and Regional Planning (TU Berlin, Germany) and at Heriot Watt University, Edinburgh, United Kingdom.

Fransiska Faletina Sugi works as a Local Advisor together with the GIZ *Entwicklungsdienst* Senior Advisor, and assists Bappeda in basic Data Management. Before joining GIZ *Entwicklungsdienst*, she has worked for the Government of Kupang Municipality in various fields such as environmental management, economic development and local planning since 1999.